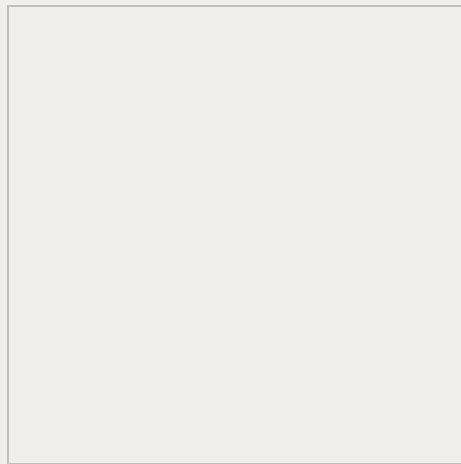


War of the Buffoons

In the early 1750s, Rameau became embroiled in a war of words about the relative merits of Italian comic opera and its more serious counterpart in France. The controversy was sparked by the success of Giovanni Battista Pergolesi's *La serva padrona* (The Servant turned Mistress). Performed by a troupe known as the Bouffons (Buffoons), this prompted the French philosopher Jean-Jacques Rousseau to produce a pamphlet praising the vigor of the Italians. A patriotic exchange of pamphlets ensued. As the leading operatic composer of the day, Rameau was often branded a reactionary figure in these texts.



ITALIAN COMPOSER GIOVANNI
BATTISTA PERGOLESİ (1710–
1736)

Jean-Philippe Rameau was born in Dijon to a musical family. His father was a church organist; Jean-Philippe took a similar path, holding a series of posts as an organist, which he combined with writing and teaching.

It was Rameau's writing that first drew him to the public's attention. His *Treatise on Harmony* (1722) caused a stir and became highly influential. Two years later, a book of harpsichord pieces cemented his reputation. He continued to compose,